Discipline and Specialty Structure

Questions for the Institute · Waga C, Pronto Digital · September 2026

This is not a list for you to approve. It is a set of questions, because the contents of this structure are yours and only its shape is mine, and I would rather ask than assume.

Before anything else: do not try to be complete

This is the most useful thing I can tell you, and it will save you a great deal of work.

We have just agreed that collaborators can request disciplines and specialties that are missing, and that you approve them. That changes what this exercise is for. You are not trying to anticipate every profession on earth. You are trying to cover the people you already have, well enough that the first wave mostly finds itself, and then the community shows you the rest.

Fifteen or twenty disciplines that fit your founding group is a better starting point than sixty that attempt to cover the world. A list that is too long is harder to search, harder to maintain, and full of entries nobody ever selects.

1. Start from the people you already have

This is the single most valuable exercise, and much of the rest follows from it.

> **Question 1**
>
> Take your founding collaborator spreadsheet. Reading down it, what do those people actually call themselves? Not what a university would call them. What they would say at a dinner party.

> **Question 2**
>
> Group those answers. How many distinct groupings do you end up with, and does any one of them hold more than a quarter of the list? If so, that grouping is probably too broad and wants splitting.

Those groupings are your first draft. They are drawn from real people rather than from theory, which makes them far more likely to be right.

2. The test for whether something is a discipline here

Two tests, and it should pass both. Would a collaborator recognise it instantly as the thing they do? And does living thirty years longer raise a real question in that field?

> **Question 3**
> For each discipline on your draft list, can you finish this sentence in one line: "Longer lives raise questions here because…" If you cannot, either the discipline does not belong, or the line simply has not been found yet. Both are worth knowing.

That sentence is not decoration. It is what a prospective collaborator reads when deciding whether the Institute is serious about their field, and it is the most persuasive thing on the page. It matters more than the label above it.

3. The fields a conventional institute would leave out

We agreed early that this taxonomy is built from the questions longer lives raise, not from academic departments, and that insurance, pensions, housing, urban design, employment, government and technology belong in the first paragraph rather than as an appendix.

> **Question 4**
> Which fields would a conventional longevity institute omit, that you want included and visible? Please name them deliberately rather than assuming I will infer them. This is where the Institute differs from everyone else, and the structure should show that at a glance.

4. How broad should a discipline be?

A discipline should be broad enough that somebody recognises it without thinking, and narrow enough to be meaningful. Medicine is the hard case: as a single discipline it will hold a very large number of specialties.

> **Question 5**
> Is Medicine one discipline, or several? And if several, split how: by setting (clinical, research, public health), by system (cardiovascular, neurological), or some other way that makes sense to the people inside it?

A rough guide I use: if a discipline would hold more than about forty specialties, consider splitting it. If it would hold two, consider merging it into a neighbour.

5. Specialties

Again, do not attempt to be exhaustive. Three to six per discipline is plenty to start. They exist so that the first collaborators find something close, and the request option handles the rest.

> **Question 6**
> For each discipline, what are the three to six specialties you would expect your founding collaborators to choose most often?

> **Question 7**
> Which specialties genuinely belong under more than one discipline? Health economics is the obvious case, sitting under both economics and public health. Naming a few now helps me check that the structure handles overlap properly, which you asked for.

6. What to leave out on purpose

> **Question 8**
> Is there anything you want deliberately excluded? A field you would rather the Institute not appear to be recruiting in, at least at first. It is far easier to add something later than to remove it once collaborators have selected it.

7. A draft list, provided to be argued with

People edit more easily than they invent, so here is a starting list. It is deliberately opinionated and includes the fields we agreed should be prominent. I expect you to cut some, rename others, and add several I have missed. Disagreeing with it is more useful to me than approving it.

Candidate discipline	Why longer lives raise questions here (draft line, yours to rewrite)

Medicine and Clinical Care	Treating people who live decades beyond the assumptions the guidelines were written under.
Public Health	Population health when the population is older than any before it.
Gerontology	The study of ageing itself, and what changes when it is no longer brief.
Psychology and Mental Health	Purpose, identity and belonging across a much longer life.
Neuroscience	Cognition over decades that earlier generations never reached.
Nutrition Science	What sustains a body for ninety or a hundred years.
Exercise and Movement Science	Maintaining capability rather than merely treating decline.
Insurance and Actuarial Science	Products priced on life expectancies that are no longer accurate.
Pensions and Retirement Income	Income designed for twenty years, now asked to last forty.
Economics	Growth, saving and consumption when the shape of a life changes.
Finance and Wealth	Holding and transferring wealth across a longer life and more generations.
Employment and the Workforce	Careers that may run sixty years, and the second and third of them.
Education and Lifelong Learning	Learning that no longer stops at twenty-five.
Housing	Homes built for a stage of life that now lasts decades longer.
Architecture and Urban Design	Streets and buildings that either include older people or quietly exclude them.
Transport and Mobility	Independence when driving is no longer the answer.
Government and Public Policy	States built around a dependency ratio that no longer holds.
Law and Regulation	Capacity, consent, work and retirement, all assumed in law to happen at certain ages.
Technology and Digital Life	Tools designed for the young, used for far longer than they were intended to be.
Social Care	Care delivered over years rather than only at the end of life.

Sociology and Family Studies	Families of four living generations rather than two.
Ethics and Philosophy	What a good life looks like when it is much longer.

8. How to send it back

However suits you. A marked-up copy of the table, a list in an email, or notes in whatever order they occur to you. I will turn it into the structure and send it back for your confirmation before anything is built.

And if you work through the founding spreadsheet and find that fifteen disciplines cover almost everybody, that is a good result rather than an incomplete one. The community will show us the rest.
